

BERNERA NEWS

A Community Newsletter 
in association with

IN MEMORIAM

DOLINA MACLENNAN



Dolina MacLennan, better known as 'Dollag Chircibost' was a much loved and irreplaceable member of our community here in Bernera.

Born in Ungeshader, Uig on 2nd March 1931 she was the 6th of 12 children from the union of Malcolm & Christina Morrison.

Following her marriage to Alexander MacLennan, Kirkibost, in August 1956, they made their home in the family home in

Kirkibost. A place that she loved and a home that was luminescent with Christian witness, love and selfless hospitality down through the generations and years.

Their marriage was blessed with 4 children, Chrissie Mary, Ian, & Twins Mina & Fiona. It was a long-standing union, lasting until Alasdair's passing in 2005, 52 years since they had exchanged their marriage vows in Miavaig, Uig Church of Scotland. A marriage strengthened and blessed by the Lords' presence and grace throughout.

Dollag's Christianity was faithful, bright and immensely practical. Her life was a life of service to others. Testimony to the servant heart, God Himself had blessed her with, exemplified by her looking after her dear mother-in-law.

Welcome to the April issue of Bernera News.

Spring has finally sprung, although the snow added a frosty edge, it has also come with sunshine, bringing relief for those hoping to make the most of the slight easing of restrictions.

Sitting out in the garden with a cup of tea whilst catching up with a friend has, I'm sure, been something we've all missed, although we all still have our part to play, and must continue to act responsibly.

We enjoy putting together this newsletter and are grateful to the small donations we have received. This month, we received a contribution from the Great Bernera Community Development Trust, which will cover the cost of the next 3 editions.

May's news will be a bumper anniversary edition and we are looking for your contributions, so please, get in touch. We are looking for pictures, articles and thoughts to share.

Her place was never empty in church throughout the whole of her life. Often out, when she may legitimately have used challenges to her health as an excuse to be absent. Characteristically clear in her views, one was always aware of how the land lay. A virtue incarnated by Philip. 'A man in whom there was no guile'.

Dollag's humour, accompanied by the trademark twinkle in her eye, was constant and mischievous. She often made others heartily laugh as her one-liner's hit them for six. Reminding us that following Jesus is not a sorrowful experience, but one of great joy.

Her grandchildren and great grandchildren were an enduring source of delight and a focus of prayer for Dollag, and we give God thanks for every remembrance we have of our dear sister in Christ now 'safe in the arms of Jesus'.

May the Lord comfort and strengthen Chrissie Mary, Ian, Mina, Fiona, the grandchildren, great-grandchildren and Dollag's surviving siblings, Calum, Katie Mary and Beathag in their loss.

'Bidh iad leamsa, tha Tighearna nan sluagh ag ràdh, anns an là sin anns an dèan mi suas mo sheudan; agus coiglidh mi iad, mar a choigleas duine a mhac fhèin a tha a' dèanamh seirbhis dha', Mal 3:17

Rev Hugh Stewart

COVID UPDATE

With the Western Isles having already returned to level 3 restrictions, and further easing due to take effect on the 16th April across Scotland, a number of things have changed. We strongly recommend that you keep up to date with all the restrictions and measures through a reputable source, for example the Scottish Government website.

From 16 April you can meet outdoors in groups of up to 6 adults from 6 different households. However, social distancing should still be observed.

You still should not meet anyone who is not in your household indoors in your home or in their home. However, you can meet one other household indoors in a public place such as a cafe or restaurant. The maximum number of people who can meet in this way is 6, from no more than 2 separate households. Again, social distancing guidelines should be followed.

There are slightly different rules for children and young people, so please check how the restrictions apply if you have children.

NHS WESTERN ISLES

The Vaccination programme is reaching an important stage as our target was to have offered a first vaccination appointment to everyone in groups 1-9 by now.

We believe that everyone in these groups has now been invited for vaccination and the vast majority have accepted. However if you are in groups 1-9 and have not yet had an appointment, please contact us ASAP to arrange your an appointment. To book an appointment please call **0808 196 8383**.

Groups 1-9

- 1 Residents in a care home for older adults, and staff working in care homes for older adults
- 2 All those 80 years of age and over, and frontline health and social care workers
- 3 All those 75 years of age and over
- 4 All those 70 years of age and over, and clinically extremely vulnerable individuals
- 5 All those 65 years of age and over
- 6 Adults aged 16 to 65 years in an at-risk group
- 7 All those 60 years of age and over
- 8 All those 55 years of age and over
- 9 All those 50 years of age and over

SECOND DOSES

The type of vaccine you received for your first dose will determine when you will be called for your second dose.

Second dose appointment invitations will be issued by letter to those eligible, so please look out for yours, which will arrive in a **blue envelope**.

By now anyone who had the AstraZeneca vaccine on or before 7th February, or anyone who had the Pfizer vaccine on or before 21st February, should now have received their appointments for a second dose.

If you haven't please get in touch with the vaccination team on **0808 196 8383** or email **wi.covidvax@nhs.scot**

DON'T LEAVE THE JOB HALF DONE - PLEASE MAKE SURE YOU ATTEND FOR YOUR SECOND DOSE.

CLEAR YOUR HEAD

Covid-19 continues to show us that people are struggling with their mental health. The Clear Your Head campaign is encouraging people to keep up any active habits they may have started during the pandemic. Please visit the website – **clearyourhead.scot** - and take on board the practical tips and ideas on how to manage your mood, keep going and feel the benefits.

SPRING TICK WARNING ADVICE

In spring when the temperatures begin to rise, ticks will start to waken and become more active.

Ticks love to hide in damp or shady spots or areas of overgrown grass or dense vegetation. Here they will perch on the edge of a leaf or blade of grass to await their next meal, which could be you or your unsuspecting pet.

Tips to prevent a tick bite:

- Wear light coloured clothing as it will be easier to spot ticks. Check regularly and brush the ticks off.
- Cover up as much skin as you can - wear long trousers, tuck trousers into socks and wear long sleeves.
- Carry a tick removing tool - and remove ticks quickly and correctly.
- When you return home, remove outer clothing and check for ticks.
- If you develop a rash that spreads out from the tick bite site, seek advice from your GP

Further information and advice is available at: **HPS Website - Ticks and Lyme disease in Scotland**

TALKING TO YOU

Words matter, give us comfort, wrap us in reassurance, and help us stay connected.

Every year thousands of people call Age Scotland, the national charity for older people. You can call us about absolutely anything. With Age Scotland, you are not alone. We're here to listen, provide friendship, and offer support. Because words matter. Our friendship line is part of our wider helpline and is open Monday to Friday 9am - 5pm. Call us for free on **0800 12 44 2222**

As well as friendship you can also call us for information and advice on:

- Benefits and entitlements
- Local services and opportunities
- Social care funding and options
- Housing and staying warm
- Legal issues such as Power of Attorney

FRESH AIR AND EXERCISE

Now the weather is improving it's a great time to think about getting outside for some fresh air and exercise when you can.

The benefits of an outdoor walk include:

- Helps clear the mind giving you the ability to think more imaginatively and efficiently
- Reduces back pain by loosening up muscles and joints in your lower back and hips
- Gets your blood pumping and improves heart health
- Increases lung capacity, improving stamina and exercise performance
- Reduces stress and increases happiness through the release of endorphins.

GARDENER'S CORNER

With spring many people's attention turns to the great outdoors, and in particular their gardens. Whether it's the decision of when to start the soon to be weekly ritual that is lawn mowing, or just that little smile as you look out of the window one day to see the first daffodil flower bravely declaring spring is finally here (usually followed swiftly by some sharp frosts and high winds!).

We'd therefore like to include a regular gardening section within the Bernera News. If you'd like to contribute, whether it's by sending us a picture, a top tip you've found of use in your garden, or just simply trying to find a new home for some spare seeds or plant pots, we'd love to hear from you. We'd also be interested in hearing from anyone who might like to write us a short piece about their gardens, or their experiences of gardening. Please contact us in the usual way.

CAN I EAT IT YET?



For some spring is a busy time of preparation and sowing. Those of us who grow our own vegetables in particular find this time both exciting, and often frustrating. Is the weather going to be suitable for the parsnips to germinate? How long can I leave it before planting out my broad beans? Where on earth can I keep my tomato plants as it's still too cold in the greenhouse but the kitchen windowsill is fast resembling something from The Day of the Triffids?

Of course, although we may grumble we almost seem to thrive on such conundrums. It perhaps makes the simple act of growing our own food that little more exciting. Not that I need anything more exciting than that first bite of a fresh tomato, or perhaps the first dig of the potato beds, followed swiftly by a boiling of the very sweetest and freshest broad beans. For me, growing my own veg has always been led by my stomach. I just love the taste of fresh fruit and vegetables. No matter how easy it is to buy carrots, nothing will ever compare to the taste of those I've grown myself, especially if they are pulled and eaten within a short timeframe. And whatever you do, don't leave me unsupervised around fresh peas - there won't be any left for the pan!

When we first moved here I knew that gardening in a different environment would have its challenges, but I've enjoyed every minute of it. Getting to know your garden, how the wind cuts through, where gets the best sun or the most frost, and especially what type of soil you have where is the same wherever you garden. Though it's perhaps just a little more extreme here. Each year I've increased the amount and variety that I've grown, with mostly good results. My strawberries last year were so sweet and juicy, the carrots earthy and crisp. However, my French beans were a disaster. I'm not deterred though. I've already sown some more to try again this year, although probably with a little more shelter. The one thing I know for sure is that nothing is predictable, some years things will grow well, others not so good.

For me this is all part of the process, and I love learning and thinking about why something might not have worked and how I might improve its chances for next year. Of course, I'm still a realist - I don't have plans to grow Bananas here in Kirkibost, but I'm certainly going to try some asparagus. It may not work, but if it does you'll have to excuse me for those few precious weeks when the crop is ready.

I'll be the one with butter dripping down her chin as she eats her own body weight of those sweet spears of loveliness.



Sam Millns
Kirkibost



POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - HEART'S VOICE

From a young age, art became a way of communicating for me – a language so to speak. I was a very shy youngster (a trait which lasted well into adulthood) and so was delighted to be blessed with an artistic ability. On paper the shyness left and through art I was able to express, and share, my hope for a better world, a sense of joy and a longing for peace.

Whilst at Lochaber High School it became clear that three subjects drew my attention – English, Art and Sport. Each of these in some form would become a major part of my life in the future. I went on to study at Glasgow School of Art which led on to a career in technical sportswear design, thus combining my interest in art and sport. Following on from this, I later co-set up a small business with my husband in extreme sports photography and journalism.

Life however took its twists and turns and after some twenty years together, my partner and I parted ways and my part in the business ended. The world of commercial art no longer held an interest for me and as I contemplated what to do next, I was swept away suddenly by a traumatic experience. The trauma and ensuing PTSD (post traumatic stress disorder) became a turning point in my life as I experienced a spiritual crisis and returned to my roots in Christianity to find solace. It was then that I discovered art as a therapeutic tool. It calmed the nerves and through the images I painted, an inner hope, joy and peace began to emerge in a

visual form. It was clear that my old life was being destroyed and a new, more peaceable one was emerging.

During this time, my focus also turned away from business to helping others who were also struggling. I started to volunteer with HUG (a mental health charity in Inverness) and was able to use my art to help with their awareness projects and NHS documentation.



On visits to Lewis to my father's croft, my friend, Chris, and I discovered the rich wool resources and began to use some of the wool waste and sheep wool to make crafts. Chris had experienced trauma through an RTA and severe head injury. As well as eking out a small living from our new craft venture, we began to offer craft workshops through Headway Highland (a brain injury supporting charity). We saw how the simple craft making processes helped others to relax, gave them a sense of achievement and improve their cognitive abilities. In 2014 I moved to Lewis and began a three-month contract

with Hebrides Alpha using craft skills, and also began to offer wool felt workshops through An Lanntair.

In the back of my mind however, I knew that while art did play an important role in my own recovery from PTSD, it was my faith in Christ that brought about true and permanent changes. So, in 2017, supported by the Church, I began to train with the Scottish Bible Society in Bible-based trauma healing. There again, I saw how art can be very effective in helping people who find it difficult to put into words their experience or pain. For people who have been traumatized, sometimes art, music, creative writing, even sport is a way in which they can begin to express their pain and loss and begin to come to terms with it. As the saying goes "a picture speaks a thousand words".

What the future holds, I do not know, but I do hope that I can continue to use art and scripture as a means of helping others to find their hope, joy and peace again.



Joanna George
Kirkibost



In our next series of postcards from the islands we'd like to focus on some of the positives that have come from such a difficult and different time that we've all experienced since Covid-19 first hit.

So, if you have a story to share, perhaps a new hobby to tell us about, please don't hesitate to get in touch.

POSTCARDS FROM THE ISLANDS - PASSIONATELY POTTY

The Pandemic has affected many people in many different ways, but it's only thanks to the last 12 months that I have discovered my love of Pottery.

At the age of 16 I was made to choose between my love of the arts and science at school, and science won. So I've spent the last 18 years focused on learning and enhancing my skills as a Pharmacist, which thankfully led me to my new life in the Hebrides. But when the lockdown began in March 2020 I wasn't able to spend my free time socialising with friends, visiting my family or having adventures across the Island, I needed to find a hobby to do at home. I tried my hand at baking, watercolour painting, charcoal

sketches, knitting, macrame and I even completed an online diploma in photography, but I wasn't really passionate about any of it. So, like many people last year, I used the time at home to sort through all the clutter in my house, where I unearthed an old mug that had been made by my Dad.



My Grandad, Percy Pitt, had owned a pottery in County Durham and my Dad had grown up learning this skill from a very young age. I decided to give pottery a try, it was in my DNA after all. I ordered some clay online and using beginner pottery books and online tutorials, I learned how to wedge the clay and hand-build some basic shapes. I love getting my hands dirty making pinch pots and I lose hours at a time to my new hobby. My Dad has a second-hand throwing wheel and when he is allowed to visit, will be giving me a lesson. Coll Pottery have kindly

offered to fire my pots in their kiln and their lessons will be starting up again soon. I've made all sorts of shapes and sizes of pots but my favourites to make are the mugs!



My dream is to one day have my own kiln and pottery shed so that I can make my mugs to my heart's content. Have you ever wanted to try something new? Give it a go this year, you never know, you might find a new passion yourself.

Katie Booth, Pharmacist,
Wannabe Potter



Katie Booth
Kirkibost



DÌTHEANAN

Seo sgeulachd eile nuair a bha mi nam nighean bheag.

Aon latha b'fheudar do ar nábaidh a dhol a choimhead air bean a' mhinistear agus chaidh mi fhín agus a mac cómhla rithe. Fhad 's a bha na h-inbhich a' bruidhinn, chluich sinne teis a' chloinn eile agus ás déidh sin ghabh sinn glainne bhainne is bonnaich le ím is silidh.

Aig an ám a dhol dhachaidh chaidh sinn a-mach dhan gháradh far an robh tórr dhítheanan álainn is eader -dhealaichte a' fàs. Dh' fhaighnich bean a' mhinistear dhomh an robh mi ag iarraidh cuid dhiubh. Bha mi toilichte is thagh mi crom-lusan ged a thuirt ise gun robh feadhainn eile nas bòidheche ann. Dh' innis i dhomh: "Bi faiceallach! Feumaidh tu coiseachd gu slaodach."



Dh' fhalbh sinn agus bha a h-uile rud ceart gu leóir gus am faca mi mo mhàthair aig an doras. Bha mi air bhioran agus ruith mi dha h-ionnsaigh ag èigheachd: "Seall a Mhamaidh, tha tiodhlac agam dhut! Thug mi na dìtheanan dhi, uill cha robh sin gu tur fíor oir cha robh bileag sam bith air fhàgail ach na gasan. Abair calldachd!"

Thoisich mi a' rànaill ach bha mo mhàthair cho coibhneil agus thuirt i: "Na bi brònach m'eudail, is caomh leam do thiodhlac gu mòr"

An uair sin chuir i na gasan ann am bhàsa.

Linne Macleod
Dun Innes



BERNERA BAKES... CHOCOLATE ORANGE CUPCAKES

Cupcake ingredients:

8 oz S.R flour
8 oz caster sugar
1 teaspoon baking powder
2 oz dark cocoa powder
8 oz Butter
4 eggs large
Juice of and zest of 1 orange
(keeping 1 tablespoon for icing)

Chocolate buttercream:

6 oz butter
12 oz icing sugar
2 oz dark cocoa powder
Packet mini chocolate orange

Method:

1. Sift all dry ingredients together, add butter and eggs to dry ingredients. Decorate as you wish. ENJOY.
2. Whisk together for a few minutes until light and fluffy.
3. Divide mixture into 16 muffin cases.
4. Bake for 20 - 25 minutes at around 180°C.

While cakes are in oven, make up buttercream.

5. Sift icing sugar & cocoa powder and whisk together with butter and 1 tablespoon orange juice.



Careen MacLennan
Kirkibost

TRUE FAITH

As the groundworks for our new bridge are being undertaken at present, perhaps, we can, for a short time allow ourselves to consider another sea crossing that lies between America and Canada, the Niagara Falls. The Falls are filled by Lake Erie and Lake Ontario, and consist of three different waterfalls. The American Falls and the Bridal Veil Falls in the USA, and Horseshoe Falls in Canada.

An impressive sight from either country as the roaring crashing sound of thousands of tonnes of water fall down upon seas below. The spray ensuring a permanent rainbow to be seen providentially framing the spectacular scene. Charles Blondin chose to cross the Niagara Falls not by bridge, plane, boat or road, but by a tightly stretched tightrope. The distance to walk - over a quarter of a mile. And so, it was in the summer of 1859 that Blondin walked the journey, 50 metres or 160 feet above the falls. Not content with just walking across the Falls, he once crossed in a sack, once on stilts, another time on a bicycle, and once he even carried a stove and cooked an omelette! A feat that takes al fresco cuisine to an unimagined height.

In July 1859, Blondin walked backward across the tightrope to Canada and returned pushing a wheelbarrow. He did this blindfolded. Having completed the task, he was serenaded with much adulation and amazement from the crowds on both sides of the Falls. They had no doubt but that he had done it. They were there and they had seen every fantastic step of his journey. Blondin then asked the crowds, "Do you believe I can carry a person across in this wheelbarrow?" Of course the crowd shouted that yes, they believed he could! Unexpectedly, he added, "Who will get in the wheelbarrow?" As one might expect, no-one volunteered.

This true story helps us to understand Christian faith. The crowds witnessed Blondin's death-defying deeds. They said that they believed he could do it, but when they were asked to put their faith into gear and act, they did not.

It is one thing to say we believe God but only when we believe God and actively place our trust and confidence in Jesus, do we experience and express true faith. True faith that believes and rests in Jesus. That He is the bridge that crosses our sin, guilt, and judgement to bring us to the far shore of Heaven, at the end of our pilgrimage here.

"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.", **Matthew 11:28**

Rev Hugh Maurice Stewart
Uig & Bernera



SCOTTISH TOWN OR CITY NAME WORD SEARCH

P	E	R	T	H	L	U	S	S	K	B	C	I	G
A	A	N	T	E	R	G	E	D	S	I	L	L	I
B	T	S	H	I	E	L	D	A	I	G	L	H	D
E	U	O	B	A	N	A	N	L	L	G	O	T	L
R	H	S	D	I	C	E	O	B	K	E	O	O	M
D	K	C	I	W	A	H	S	E	I	R	P	B	U
E	I	D	R	O	F	G	B	A	U	R	L	E	R
E	R	U	Y	T	R	E	O	T	C	W	L	R	D
N	K	N	A	A	S	E	T	T	I	A	U	M	N
G	C	B	L	F	S	D	I	I	N	H	C	O	Y
A	A	L	R	F	S	N	A	E	E	S	U	R	T
R	L	A	A	O	T	U	E	T	P	I	P	Y	G
V	D	N	A	M	T	D	E	S	F	W	A	Y	L
E	Y	E	L	L	S	L	L	A	W	K	R	I	K

Kirkwall
Dice
Perth
Dundee
Hawick
Moffat
Ae
Oban
Tobermory
Ayr
Cupar
Penicuik
Biggar
Gretna
Aberdeen

Ullapool
Tobson
Largs
Shieldaig
Dalbeattie
Shotts
Tyndrum
Wishaw
Dunblane
Luss
Kirkcaldy
Garve

Colin Halliday
Kirkbost

